A Midsummer Night's Dream: Writer's Methods & Techniques

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Writer's Methods and Techniques

"Writer's methods and techniques" is an umbrella term for anything the writer or playwright does on purpose to create meaning. Using the writer's name in your response will help you to think about the text as a conscious construct and will keep reminding you that William Shakespeare purposely put the text together.

The best responses at IGCSE don't limit their analysis to individual words and phrases. Examiners are really looking for analysis of Shakespeare's overall aims, so try to take a "whole-text" approach to his methods and techniques as a playwright. Below are some of the methods and techniques used in A Midsummer Night's Dream.

- Form and structure
- Motifs and symbolism

Examiner Tips and Tricks

In the exam, the question may involve the command word "how" and will refer to the author. This invites you to explore the craft of writing/the writer's methods and go beyond the "what" of the text to thinking about the text as a conscious construct, exploring what the writer has done deliberately to create meaning.

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

Form and structure

The form and structure of A Midsummer Night's Dream demonstrate William Shakespeare's mastery in crafting a multi-layered narrative. The play is a classic example of a Shakespearean comedy as it includes mishaps and confusion but, ultimately, has a romantic resolution.

actors preparing and performing their play
    - These plots run **concurrently**, influencing one another, which adds depth to the narrative by exploring different **facets** of love and fantasy

- The play exhibits a symmetrical design with the events in Athens mirrored by those in the forest:
    - The romantic conflicts and resolutions in both settings echo each other
    - This symmetry emphasises the magical and transformative nature of the forest, where the characters' normal boundaries are disrupted

- Shakespeare uses verse and prose to reveal the status and relationships of his characters in their speeches:
    - He uses **rhymed verse** for the Athenian lovers when they are speaking of their love
    - He uses blank verse, or unrhymed **iambic pentameter** for noble characters, such as the Duke
    - He uses prose for lower status characters such as Bottom and the Mechanicals
    - It is worth noting that, when performing their play, the Mechanicals try to speak in rhymed verse to portray an elevated status but they do not succeed, adding to the comedic effect
    - This stylistic choice helps differentiate between the social classes

- The play has an **episodic** structure with distinct scenes, each contributing to the overall narrative but also capable of standing alone:
    - This episodic structure allows for the exploration of various comedic situations

- The play incorporates a play within a play framework:
    - The performance of the play by the Mechanicals, who are amateur actors, is a play embedded within a larger narrative
    - This structure serves both as a comedic **interlude** and a reflection on the themes of love and imagination

Motifs and symbolism

A motif is a recurring or repeated pattern that is a common literary device that helps establish a theme or mood, while a symbol might occur once to convey an idea or an emotion. Shakespeare uses a range of motifs and symbols in A Midsummer Night's Dream.

- A Midsummer Night's Dream is built upon the idea of contrast and it is a central motif:
    - Nearly every character in the play has an opposite, creating a pattern of doubles
    - For example, Lysander is a **chivalrous** gentleman whereas Demetrius is cruel and unkind to Helena

- The three main groups of characters, drawn from various sources like Greek mythology and folklore, are intended

- The motif of love as a transformative force also runs throughout the play:
  - Characters undergo changes in their emotions and relationships under the influence of love
- The interplay between dreams and reality is also a recurring motif:
  - Characters experience dreams and visions, and the boundaries between the dream world and reality blur
  - This is especially evident during the magical night in the forest
- The motif of nature is intertwined with the play's themes, especially in the forest setting:
  - The forest becomes a world where the characters confront their true selves
  - This motif emphasises the connection between human emotions and nature
  - Animals such as "wolf" or "wild beasts" are often referred to, symbolising untamed or wild feelings
- The moon is a recurring motif, representing magic, love and mystery:
  - References to the moon's influence on love, such as Oberon's spell being cast at night, contribute to the play's enchanting atmosphere
  - Nighttime settings enhance the dreamlike quality of the play
  - The play begins and ends with a reference to the moon, which emphasises the cyclical and timeless nature of love and the magical elements in the story
- Flowers are a recurring motif that symbolise love and enchantment:
  - The magical flower's juice, the use of flowers in the spell and the weaving of flowers into Bottom's hair are symbolic of love's influence

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